seats. For his part, the caretaker prime minister Anwarul Haq Kakar, whose government oversaw the election process, defended the results, arguing that "if rigging had really been planned, would those that won the highest number of seats have been allowed to win them?"

With no single party in a position to form a government on its own at the national level, and none of them in favour of having another general election, a coalition government was the only way forward. From jail, Imran ruled out the option of the PTI joining up with any of the other main parties. The only alternative, therefore, was what some are dubbing PDM 2.0, a reference to the Pakistan Democratic Movement (PDM) coalition that took over for a year and a half after Imran's government lost power through a no-confidence vote in April 2022. Both the PML-N and the PPP were an integral part of the PDM government and, along with a host of other parties opposed to Imran, can easily get the numbers this time to run a coalition.

Complicating the issue, though, are the deep cleavages that extend to the provincial assemblies—elections to which were held simultaneously. In Punjab, Pakistan's most powerful province, the PML-N won 137 out of the total 297 general seats, 12 short of a simple majority of 149 seats. That was largely because of the PTI unexpectedly winning 116 seats, splitting the vote almost right down the middle. In Khyber Pakhtunkhwa, the PTI won an overwhelming majority, bagging 84 out of its 115 general seats, and will form the government in this restive frontier province. The country's third big player, the PPP, retained its own stronghold of Sindh with 84 out of 130 general seats. Balochistan had an intriguing three-way split that could see the PPP form a government with a coalition.



AP

Pakistan's economy remains in a shambles. It will likely have to enter another restrictive IMF support programme in order to stay afloat

SHEHBAZ'S BITTER CUP

As PDM 2.0 gets down to working out conditions that will help it set up a government at the federal level, there will be plenty of hard bargaining between the PML-N and the PPP, making it far from smooth sailing. From the initial assertions of intent, it seems former premier Shehbaz Sharif rather than his elder brother Nawaz Sharif will be the new prime minister. Nawaz had already indicated before the election that he would not like to become premier for a fourth time if the PML-N did not get a clear mandate in the election. Political pundits also say the military had quietly indicated its preference for working with Shehbaz. In the past, too, they were more comfortable dealing with him rather than Nawaz, who was prone to striking out on a more independent path. But Shehbaz will be leading a minority government because, for now, the PPP has decided not to seek cabinet positions in the new government, though it says it will support the PML-N to form the government. Both PPP co-chairman Bilawal Bhutto-Zardari and PML-N president Shehbaz Sharif announced they were forming the government "in the larger interests of the country" rather than out of any great joy.

The PPP's reluctance to become a direct partner in government perhaps stems from the realisation that formal power at this juncture may be a crown of thorns. There's also the party's public misgivings about its experience in the previous PDM government and the consideration how allying with its erstwhile rivals could play out for its political fortunes in the future. Pakistan's economy remains in a shambles: there has been a contraction in growth, much of it because of Imran's mismanagement while in power, though the blame accrued to the PDM government that succeeded him. Inflation continues to hover at 40 per cent and prices of all essentials, including fruits, vegetables and